

TN.5 Forms & Documents Index

Every document you will meet, named as the agency names it — and the things Tennessee never asks you for.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Tennessee adopts one state residential code and then gives your jurisdiction three different ways to answer for it: run its own building department, let the State Fire Marshal enforce the state code through contract inspectors, or opt out entirely so that no residential building code is enforced at all. The unit is the **jurisdiction**, not the county — a city inside an opted-out county routinely has a different status from the county around it. What does not depend on any of that: the state electrical permit, the subsurface sewage disposal permit, and contractor licensing. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Form numbers and fees were read from the agencies' own current forms in September 2026. Where no form number is published, this document says so rather than inventing one.

THE STATE DOCUMENTS

What the state issues, and what it costs

Document	What it is	Fee
CN-0971 Application for Water Resources Services	The one form that covers septic and most water services. The septic construction permit is line item 1. Its own instruction routes it: "mail your application and fee to the office associated with your county shown on the next page"	\$400 permit evaluation up to 1,000 gpd; \$100 construction inspection
State residential building permit	No form number is published. The rule requires only "a form prescribed by the Department" and permitting now runs through CORE at core.tn.gov. Anyone quoting you a form number is guessing	Banded on construction cost — see TN.2
Residential property owner's electrical permit	The homeowner's own electrical permit. Covers you and immediate family only, allows no unlicensed helpers, and only one per twelve months	\$35 rough-in, \$35 final at 0–200 amp
Notice of Intent to drill a water well	Filed by the owner or the licensed driller before drilling starts . The driller must be able to document it on site. Expires in 180 days	\$75 per property site
Report of Well Driller	The completion report and well log, filed within 60 days . Includes latitude and longitude to the nearest second and confirmation that septic is 50 feet or more away. Get a copy — it is your well's only record	Filed by the driller

What the state issues, and what it costs

Document	What it is	Fee
Certificate of occupancy	Issued by the Division after all required inspections and the final electrical inspection pass. In an opt-out jurisdiction you can request one voluntarily	Included; \$100 for a temporary one

One item we are flagging rather than explaining. CN-0971 also lists a **Certificate of Verification** at \$100, but rule chapter 0400-48-01 never uses the phrase and the form does not say when it is needed. It reads like the document evidencing an approved system at a sale or closing. Ask the field office rather than assuming you need it.

THE LOCAL DOCUMENTS — IF THEY EXIST WHERE YOU ARE

In an EXEMPT jurisdiction the local government issues its own paperwork under its own names, and there is no statewide vocabulary for it. These are the ones that exist nearly everywhere they exist at all. Write in what yours calls them.

What my jurisdiction calls each document

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Building permit application — and whether there is a separate homeowner or owner-builder version: Called _____ Separate form? _____		
☐	Owner-builder affidavit. No state Board form exists; the affirmations are built into the permit application. Local jurisdictions often have their own: Called _____		
☐	Zoning or land-use permit , if separate from the building permit: Called _____ Issued by _____		
☐	Driveway or culvert permit: Called _____ Road authority _____		
☐	911 address application: Called _____ Issued by _____		
☐	Floodplain development permit , if in a mapped hazard area: Called _____ Administrator _____		

What my jurisdiction calls each document

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Certificate of occupancy — ask whether the local jurisdiction issues one, because not all do: Answer _____		

WHAT NEEDS NO STATE PERMIT AT ALL

Verified from the State Fire Marshal's own guidance. **This is the state program's answer** — a local jurisdiction running its own code may require permits for all of it, so ask before you rely on any line here.

No state permit required

What	The condition
Detached garages, sheds, barns	No state permit for detached structures not used for living purposes . The moment it contains a dwelling unit, that changes
Placing a manufactured or modular home	No state permit to install one. But the site work is different: a site-built deck, patio or stoop attached to it needs a manufactured or modular site work permit
Renovations to an existing house	The state program covers new construction and additions only. Renovation is outside it
Additions under 30 sq ft	Additions of 30 square feet or more of interior space need a permit. Below that, no. The existing house does not have to be brought up to code — the addition does

WHAT TENNESSEE DOES NOT REQUIRE

Worth knowing because owner-builders arriving from other states routinely budget for these. Under the **state** program, none of them is mandatory.

- **A blower door test.** The mandatory whole-house air leakage test was replaced with a choice between a testing option and a visual inspection against a checklist.
- **Duct leakage testing.** Both the mandatory and the prescriptive provisions are optional.
- **Residential fire sprinklers.** Not mandatory in one- and two-family dwellings or townhouses. Because townhouses go unsprinklered, they must instead be separated by two-hour fire walls.
- **A separate energy or insulation inspection.** Energy compliance is observed during the inspections you are already having.
- **A state owner-builder affidavit form.** The Board for Licensing Contractors publishes no such thing. The affirmations live on the permit application you sign.

All five are the state program's answers, and an EXEMPT jurisdiction may differ on every one of them. A city on a newer local energy code can require a blower door; a local ordinance can require sprinklers.

This list tells you what the state will not ask for — not what your building official will not ask for.

THE ONE THING YOU MAY NOT DO YOURSELF

Tennessee is generous about owner-performed work. You may act as your own general contractor, wire your own house on a homeowner electrical permit, and do your own plumbing. **You may not drill your own well.**

The sentence that kills the "my builder will handle it" assumption

TDEC states it without hedging: "Tennessee licensed **general contractors, licensed electricians, and licensed plumbers ARE NOT permitted** to install or perform maintenance on water wells, water well pumps, or water well treatment systems **unless they are also licensed by the TDEC, Division of Water Resources.**"

The rules bar *any person* from constructing a well except in accordance with the Water Wells Act, and they carve out no exemption for owners. The owner's recognized role is on the *paperwork* — you may file the Notice of Intent yourself — which is easy to misread as permission to dig. It is not. The one physical task the rules do let a landowner perform is **abandoning a hand-dug well less than sixty feet deep.**

The rules are the part you actually need, and they are free. publications.tnsosfiles.com hosts them as dated PDFs — **0780-02-23** residential, **0780-02-01** electrical, **0400-48-01** septic — and the filename carries the effective date, so you can always tell whether yours is current. Statutes are published under contract by LexisNexis at lexisnexis.com/hottopics/tncode. **One warning:** building and electrical rest on separate authority — Title 68, Chapter 120 and Title 68, Chapter 102. Conflating them is why so many guides wrongly imply that opting out of the building code ends your permit obligations. It does not. Read September 2026.